

Anecdotes about Einstein

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A Wastebasket for His Mistakes

When Albert Einstein arrived in America at age 54, pulling into¹ New York Harbor on the ocean liner *Westernland* on October 17, 1933, an **official**³ greeting committee was waiting for him. Einstein and his entourage², however, were nowhere to be found.

1. pull into 表示驶入, 原文的意思是: Albert Einstein traveled on the ocean liner(邮轮) called *Westernland* to America when he was 54. The liner pulled into New York Harbor and an official committee was waiting for him and his family members.
2. Entourage 表示随从人员。从全文判断, 此处的 entourage 主要指的是 his family members.
3. Don't confound "official" with "officer". 前者是形容词, 表示官方的; 后者为名词, 指官员。E.g. 这人说话官腔官调: He speaks with an official tone.

Abraham Flexner, director of the Institute for Advanced Study in Princeton, New Jersey, **was obsessed with shielding** his celebrity professor from publicity⁴. So he'd sent a tugboat to spirit the great man away from the *Westernland* as soon as it **cleared quarantine**⁵. His hair poking out from a wide-brimmed black hat, Einstein surreptitiously **disembarked**⁶ onto the tug, which ferried⁷ him and his party to lower Manhattan, where a car would whisk them to Princeton. "All Dr. Einstein wants is to be left in peace and quiet," Flexner told reporters.

4. Be obsessed with means unable to stop thinking about something 无法停止思考, 反反复复想。原文 Flexner was obsessed with shielding Einstein from publicity 可以理解成 F 教授一心只想让爱因斯坦远离公众的视线。Shield 表示盾牌, 名词作动词, 即 to protect.
5. Spirit means 1) soul 精神, 灵魂; 2) ghost 鬼魂。此处名词做动词用, 表示神不知鬼不觉地带离; "To spirit the great man away from the *Westernland*" means to guide Einstein from the ship to a small boat stealthily 偷偷摸摸地, quietly 静悄悄地。后文 as soon as it cleared quarantine, quarantine 表示检验检疫。国际船只到港后, 都需要进行人员和物品的安检。安检通过后方可放行。Clear here means to pass, 表示通过(检疫); "...as soon as it cleared quarantine" means once the ship **passed** the quarantine, Einstein was directed into a small tugboat.
6. Surreptitiously means stealthily 是一个超纲词, 不要记忆。同学们理解文意即可。Disembark(下船上岸) means to get off from(a ship). So "Einstein surreptitiously disembarked onto the tug" means Einstein quietly got off from the ship *Westernland* and got on the small tug.
7. Ferry means to carry by boat.

Winner of the Nobel Prize in 1921 for his contribution to **theoretical physics**⁸, Einstein was given an office at the institute. He was asked what equipment he needed. "A desk or table, a chair, paper and pencils," he replied. "Oh, and a large wastebasket, so I can throw away all my mistakes."

8. Theoretical is the adjective of theory. And don't confound "physics" with "physicist".

Physics is a discipline 表示学科; physicist is a specialist in physics 表示物理学家

He and Elsa, his wife, rented a house and **settled**(安置) into life in Princeton. He liked the fact that America, despite its **inequalities** of **wealth**(richness 财富) and racial **injustices**, was more of a meritocracy than Europe. "What makes the new arrival devoted to this country is the democratic trait(=feature 特征) among the people," he would later **marvel**(=wonder 感叹, 惊叹). "No one humbles himself before another person."

Not Always an Einstein

Einstein, however, was no Einstein when he was a child. Growing up in Munich, Germany, the first of two children of Hermann and Pauline Einstein, he was slow in learning how to talk. "My parents were so worried," he recalled, "that they **consulted** a doctor."

Even when he began using words after age two, he developed a quirk that **prompted** his nursemaid to dub him the dopey one⁹. "Every sentence he uttered, no matter how routine," recalled his younger sister, Maja, "he repeated to himself softly, moving his lips." His slow development was combined with a cheeky rebelliousness toward authority, which led one German schoolmaster to send him packing¹⁰. Another declared that Einstein would never **amount to**¹¹ much.

9. Quirk means a strange habit 表示怪癖; **prompt** means to cause to do 表示促使; dub means to nickname somebody, 即给某人取小名.

So the first sentence of this paragraph means even when Einstein began to speak at the age of two, he formed a strange habit which caused his nursemaid to call him a "fool".

10. Send sb packing is a fixed phrase. 这是一个固定搭配, 表示 to send one away rudely 把某人赶出;

11. Amount to is a phrasal verb 是一个动词短语. It means to become successful. It is often used with "much", "anything" as in "amount to anything," or "amount to much." So the last sentence means another professor had declared that Einstein would never succeed.

"When I ask myself how it happened that I discovered the relativity theory, it seemed to lie in the following **circumstance**(=condition, situation)," Einstein later explained. "The ordinary adult never **bothers his head about**¹² the problems of space and time. These are things he has thought of as a child. But I developed so slowly that I began to wonder about space and time only when I was already grown up. I **probed**(=study, examine) more deeply into the problem than an ordinary child would have."

12. Bother his head about means to become anxious or concerned about, 关心某物, 为某物感到困惑或焦虑. The sentence "the ordinary adult never bothers his head about the problems of space and time" means a common adult is rarely concerned with space and time. 普通成年人压根不关心空间和时间。

A Merry Science

Encouraged by his genial father, who ran a family business, and his music-loving mother, Einstein spent hours working on puzzles and building towers with toys. "**Persistence**(毅力) and **tenacity**(坚韧) were part of his character," his sister remarked.

Once, when Einstein was sick in bed as a preschooler, his father brought him a **compass**(指南针). Einstein later remembered being so excited as he **examined**(=investigate, analyse) its mysterious powers that he **trembled** and grew cold. The **magnetic needle**(磁针) behaved as if influenced by a hidden force field, rather than through a mechanical method of touch or contact. "Something deeply hidden had to be behind things," he said.

He **marveled at**¹³ magnetic fields, gravity, inertia and light beams. He **retained** the ability(此处的“能力”就是 curiosity) to hold two thoughts in his mind simultaneously, to be puzzled when they **conflicted**¹⁴ and to delight when he saw an **underlying** unity¹⁵. "People like you and me never grow old," he wrote a friend years later. "We never cease to stand like curious children before the great mystery into which we were born."

13. Marvel means to become filled with surprise, wonder or amazement 惊叹于。如果 Marvel 大写，就是专有名词，表示美国的漫威漫画公司；

14. Retain means to keep something in mind, to remember 表示保留。Conflict means to contradict, 相矛盾；underlying means hidden, not obvious.

15. Delight is not only a noun, but also a verb. E.g. His musical performance was indeed a **delight**.他的演奏会真是赏心悦目。His musical performance **delighted** the audience.

Contrary to widespread belief, Einstein **excelled at**(=was good at) math. By the age of 13, "he already had a predilection for solving **complicated**(=complex) problems in applied arithmetic," his sister recalled. An uncle, Jakob Einstein, an engineer, introduced him to the joys of algebra, calling it a "**merry**(=pleasant, happy) science," and whenever Einstein triumphed, he "**was overcome with**(=was overwhelmed with, was full of, was filled with) happiness."

From his reading of popular science books, which showed him that "much in the Bible could not be true," Einstein developed a **resistance** to all forms of dogma. As he wrote in 1901, "A foolish **faith** in authority is the worst enemy of truth."

A Proud American

At age 15, Einstein left Germany for northern Italy, where his parents relocated their business, and at 16, he wrote his first essay on theoretical physics.

Einstein's discovery of special relativity, after he graduated from the Zurich Polytechnic in 1900 when he was 21, involved an intuition based on intellectual as well as personal experience¹⁶. He developed the theory starting in 1905, after taking a job at the Swiss patent office. But his theory was not fully accepted until 1919, when observations made during a solar eclipse confirmed his **prediction**(预测) of how much the gravity of the sun would bend light beams.

16. In the first sentence "Einstein's discovery of special relativity... **involved an intuition based on intellectual as well as personal experience**," the word "intellectual" relates to the intellect 与智力有关；"involve" means to include something as part of it. 因此，这句话要理解成，狭义相对论的发现部分来自于爱因斯坦的直觉，这种直觉建立在他的智力和个人经验之上。

At age 40, in 1919, Einstein was suddenly world famous. He was also married to Elsa, his second wife, and was the father of two sons from his first marriage. By spring 1921, his exploding global fame led to a **grand**¹⁷ two-month visit to the United States, where he received so warm a welcome that he would evoke mass frenzy¹⁸ wherever he went. The world had never seen such a scientific **celebrity**¹⁹ superstar.

17. Grand means large and striking in size, extent, lavish(奢华的) 表示隆重的, 盛大的 E.g. a grand celebration 隆重的庆典;
18. Evoke means raise, inspire 激起; mass here is an adjective, meaning affecting a large number of people. E.g. mass destruction 大规模摧毁, mass frenzy 大众的狂热;
19. Celebrity is a noun, meaning the state of being celebrated 名望, 但英语中的名词地位高, 名词本身不仅能做动词使用, 还能做形容词修饰另一个名词, 如 the celebrity professor, the celebrity couple.

Einstein loved America, appreciating that its bursts²⁰ of exuberance were the result of freedom and individualism. In March 1933, with Hitler in power in Germany, Einstein realized he could no longer live in Europe. By that fall, he'd settled in Princeton, and by 1940, he was a naturalized(此处, naturalized 表示被授予美国国籍, 属于超纲词汇) citizen, proud to call himself an American.

20. Burst means outburst.

The Harmony of Nature and Math

His first Halloween living in America, Einstein disarmed some astonished trick-or-treaters by serenading them at the door with his violin²¹. At Christmas, when members of a local church came by to sing carols, he stepped outside, borrowed a violin and merrily accompanied them.

21. Disarm 本身表示卸下武装, 文中指消除了捣蛋的孩子们的敌意。Serenade means to play a serenade for 表示为谁演奏一首小夜曲。爱因斯坦为万圣节前来捣蛋的孩子们演奏了一首小夜曲, 消除了他们的敌意。

Einstein soon **acquired**²¹ an image, which grew into a near legend, of being a kindly professor, distracted at times but **unfailingly**(=constantly, everlastingly 始终, 一直保持地) sweet, who rarely **combed**(梳理) his hair or wore socks. "I've reached an age when, if somebody tells me to wear socks, I don't have to," he told some local children.

22. Acquire means to obtain or gain something. The first sentence in this paragraph means that Einstein gradually formed an image of a kindly professor whose mind sometimes was beyond comprehension but who was constantly gentle.

He once helped a 15-year-old student, Henry Rosso, with a journalism class. Rosso's teacher had offered a top grade to anyone scoring²² an interview with the scientist, so Rosso showed up at the Einstein home, only to be rebuffed(=to be rejected sharply 被生硬地回绝) at the door. The milkman gave him a tip: Einstein walked a certain route each morning at 9:30. Rosso snuck(sneak 溜) out of school and accosted(搭讪) him.

23. Score here means to achieve, or accomplish. 也就是说, Rosso 的老师规定, 谁能成功

和爱因斯坦搭上话，谁就能拿最高分。结果，Rosso 第一次就被爱因斯坦给拒之门外（rebuff）了。

But the student, suddenly all confused, didn't know what to ask. So Einstein suggested questions about math. "I discovered that nature was constructed in a wonderful way, and our task is to find out [its] mathematical structure," Einstein explained about his own education. "It is a kind of faith that helped me through my whole life."

The interview earned²³ Henry Rosso an A.

24. Earn here means to make somebody obtain 使某人获得. E.g. Her unique suggestion earned her a promotion. 她因独特的提议获得了晋升。原文的意思是 The interview with Einstein made Rosso obtain an A.